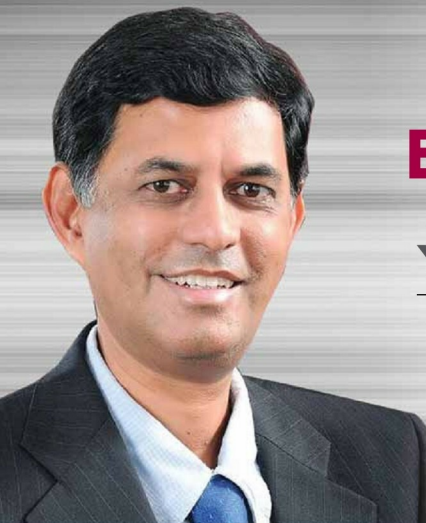




FOSS Experts, Where Are You Hiding?

Silvan Innovation Labs is a Bengaluru-based company that provides security solutions and home automation systems. It plans to recruit over 80 FOSS professionals in a year, but one of its biggest problems is finding suitable candidates. Dr Giri Krishna, CEO, Silvan Innovation Labs, talks to Jalaja Ramanunni of the *Linux For You* about how the FOSS scene is growing big internationally, while in India, it still needs pepping up.

Q How has the demand for FOSS experts changed over the recent years?

Linux has been around for a long time, but people were waiting for it to be a mature solution. Large product companies would not consider open source, as they doubted its stability—but now, the research and development phase is over. Over the years, FOSS has proved its stability in the industry, and many organisations are switching to using open source solutions rather than conventional proprietary solutions, because of the high costs associated with the latter. FOSS is very mature now, and it is possible to run Linux on a variety of platforms, making it a favourable commercial solution. This has led to a demand for FOSS professionals, especially in organisations that deal with technology and products. With the Android explosion, Linux on hand-held or embedded devices is an upcoming area, and will see much more growth in the coming years, especially because over 50 per cent of smart-phones run on Android today. The main sectors driving this demand are industries

like technology, semi-conductors, telecom companies and phone manufacturers.

Q Why aren't there enough developers from India who participate in the FOSS community?

India needs many more developers with a Linux background. There is a shortage now, because most of them do not get FOSS training in their universities. In the US, UNIX and Linux is a part of the curriculum—but here, the focus is more on languages like C and C++, not on building knowledge on operating systems. Even during recruitment and placements, candidates are tested for expertise in language, and not operating systems.

Q Do you interact with the FOSS community regularly?

The Linux community is extremely helpful, and we often take its help. There is constant interaction at all stages, and when we get stuck somewhere, we depend on experts on the forums. For example, when we posted a query while facing problems with the kernel, we received responses in less than 24 hours.